Chart by u/DPenner1
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Timeline of Writing Systems' Graphical Evolution

2000 BC · 1800 BC · 1600 BC · 1400 BC · 1200 BC · 1000 BC · 800 BC · 600 BC · 400 BC · 200 BC · 1 AD · 200 AD · 400 AD · 600 AD · 800 AD · 1000 AD · 1200 AD · 1400 AD · 1600 AD · 1800 AD · 1850 AD · 1900 AD · 1950 AD · 2000 AD

Modern Era (timescale change)

Legend

- **Hellenic**: Scripts derived from Greek
- **Sinitic**: Scripts derived from Oracle Bone
- **Northern Brahmi**: Scripts derived from Brahmi in North India
- **Semitic**: Scripts derived from Proto-Sinaitic
- **Southern Brahmi**: Scripts derived from Brahmi in South India
- **Other**: Independently derived scripts (graphically)

Bold: Over 10 million users
Bold underline: Over 100 million users
Italics: Not in Unicode
Script extinction then revival:
▼▲◄► **Writing direction**
文 **Logograph**: Words are distinct characters
か **Syllabary**: Syllables are distinct characters
ふ ぇ Ω **Alphabets**: Consonants are distinct characters
Ω **True alphabet**: Vowels are on par with consonants
ぇ **Abugida**: Vowels are secondary, usually diacritics
ふ **Abjad**: Vowels are optional or non-existant

Central & East Asia

文か *Jurchen* ►
文 *Classical Yi* ▼ — か Modern Yi ►
文 *Khitan Large* ▼◄
か Nushu ▼
文か Khitan Small ▼◄
文 **Simplified Chinese** ▼►
文 *Oracle Bone* ▼ — 文 *Large Seal* ▼ — 文 *Small Seal* ▼ — 文 Clerical ▼ — 文 **Regular / Traditional Chinese (Hanzi / Kanji / Hanja / Chu Han)** ▼►
か *Man'yogana* ▼ — Ωか **Bopomofo** ►◄
か **Katakana** ▼►
か **Hiragana** ▼► — Reform: obsoleted kana named Hentaigana
ふ Khwarezmian ◄
ふ Old Sogdian ◄ — ふ Sogdian ◄▼ — Ω Mongolian ▼
from Aramaic (West Asia)
Ωふ Old Uyghur ▼◄►
ぇ New Tai Lue ► — from Tai Tham (Southeast Asia)
文 Tangut ▼
Ω Old Turkic ◄ — ぇ Tai Le ► — from Lik-Tai (Southeast Asia)
ぇ Marchen ►
Ωか **Hangul** ►▼
ぇ Zanabazar square ► — ぇ Soyombo ►
Ωぇか 'Phags-pa ▼ — from Pitman Shorthand — ぇ Pollard Miao ► — Ωぇ Fraser / Lisu ►
ぇ Tibetan ►
from Latin (Europe) — ぇ Khema ►
ぇ Lepcha ►
ぇ Limbu ►
ぇ Kirat Rai ►
ぇ Meitei ►
ぇ Bhaiksuki ► — Ωぇ Sunuwar ►
ぇ *Ranjana* ►
ぇ Prachalit / Newa ►
ぇ Tirhuta ►
ぇ *Gaudi* ► — ぇ **Odia** ►
ぇ **Bengali-Assamese** ►
ぇ *Gupta* ► — ぇ Siddham ►
ぇ Sylheti Nagri ►
ぇ Kaithi ► — Ω *Chisoi* ►
ぇ Modi ► — Ω Toto ►
ぇ Gunjala Gondi ►
ぇ **Gujarati** ►
ぇ Northern Nagari ► — ぇ **Devanagari** ►
ぇ *Nagari* ► — ぇ Masaram Gondi ►
ぇ Nandinagari ► — ぇ Dogri ► — Ω Tolong Siki ►
ぇ *Devasesa* ► — ぇ Takri ► — Ω Ol Onal ►
ぇ Sharada ►
ぇ Khojki ► — Ω Mru ►
ぇ Multani ► — Ω Wancho ►
ぇ *Landa* ► — ぇ Khudabadi ►
ぇ **Gurmukhi** ►
ぇふ Mahajani ►
ぇ Brahmi ► — Ω Warang Citi ►
ぇ *Kadamba* ► — ぇ *Telugu-Kannada* ► — ぇ **Kannada** ► — ぇ **Telugu** ►
Ω Sorang Sompeng ►
ぇ **Tamil** ►
ぇ **Sinhala** ►
ぇ **Malayalam** ► — ぇ *Tigalari-Malayalam* ► — ぇ Tigalari ►
ぇ *Pallava* ► — ぇ Grantha ►
ぇ Saurashtra ►
ぇ Evela Akuru ► — ぇ Dhives Akuru ► — Ω Mundari Bani ►
Ω Avestan ◄
ぇ Thaana ◄
ぇ Chakma ►
ぇ Ahom ► — Ω Ol Chiki ►
from Latin (Europe) — Ω Tangsa ►
Ω Pau Cin Hau ► — Ω Hanifi Rohingya ◄
ぇ *Lik-Tai* ►
ぇ *Old Mon* ► — ぇ **Mon-Burmese** ► — Ω Kayah Li ►
ぇ Tai Tham ►
ぇ Lai Tay / Tai Yo ▼
ぇ Tai Viet ►
ぇ **Khmer** ►
ぇ *Sukhothai* ► — ぇ **Thai** ►
ぇ *Fakkham* ► — ぇ Lao ►
ぇ Pahawh Hmong ►
ぇ Cham ►
ぇ Batak ►
ぇ Ulu ► — ぇ Rejang ►
ぇ Old Sundanese ► — ぇ Sundanese ►
ぇ Balinese ►
ぇ Kawi ► — ぇ Javanese ►
ぇ Makasar ►
ぇ Lontara / Bugis ►
ぇ Tagbanwa ►
ぇ Baybayin ►
ぇ Hanuno'o ►
ぇ Buhid ►

South Asia

Southeast Asia

~2800 BC — 文か *Indus* ◄►
ふ Kharosthi ◄

West Asia
(excl. Anatolia & Caucasus)

ふ Elymaic ◄ — ふ *Book Pahlavi* ◄
ふ Inscriptional Pahlavi ◄ — Ω Yezidi ◄
ふ Hatran ◄ — ふ Psalter Pahlavi ◄
ふ Nabataean ◄ — ふ **Arabic** ◄
かΩ Old Persian Cuneiform ► — ふ Hebrew ◄
~2800 BC — 文か Sumero-Akkadian Cuneiform ►
ふ Manichaean ◄
ふ Palmyrene ◄
ふ Ugaritic ► — ふ Aramaic ◄
ふ *Proto-Canaanite* ◄►▼ — ふ Phoenician ◄ — ふ Syriac ◄
ふ Inscriptional Parthian ◄ — Ω Mandaic ◄
ふ Ancient North Arabian ◄
ふ *Paleo-Hebrew* ◄ — ふ Samaritan ◄
ふ Ancient South Arabian ◄►

Africa

ふ *Proto-Sinaitic* ◄►▼
ふ *Old Ge'ez* ◄ — ぇ **Ge'ez** ►
ふ *Libyco-Berber* ▲◄ — Ω Bassa Vah ►
ふ Tifinagh ▲◄ — Ω Neo-Tifinagh ►
Ω Medefaidrin ►
Ω Garay ◄
~3250 BC — 文ふ Egyptian Hieroglyphs ◄►▼
Ω Osmanya ► — Ω Adlam ◄
ぇかΩ Meroitic Hieroglyphics ◄►
か Bamum ► — Ω N'Ko ◄
文ふ Hieratic ◄ — 文ふ Abnormal Hieratic ◄ — Ω Zaghawa / Beria ►
ぇかΩ Meroitic Cursive ◄ — か Mende Kikakui ◄
文ふ *Demotic* ◄ — か Vai ►
Ω Coptic ►
Ω Sidetic ◄

Europe, Anatolia & Caucasus

文 Anatolian Hieroglyphs ► — Ω Elbasan ► — Ω Vithkuqi ► — Ω SignWriting ►▼
文か Linear A ► — か文 Linear B ► — Ω *Night Writing* ►◄ — Ω Braille ►
Ω Caucasian Albanian ►
か Cypro-Minoan ► — か Cypriot ◄ — Ω Armenian ►
Ω Asomtavruli ► — Ω Nushkuri ► — Ω Mkhedruli ►
Ω **Greek** ► — Greek miniscule (lowercase letter forms)
Ω Carian ►◄ — Ω Gothic ► — Ω Old Permic ► — Ω Todhri ►
Ω Lydian ◄ — Ω **Cyrillic** ►
Ω Lycian ► — Ω Glagolitic ► — Ω Shavian ►
Ω Old Italic ►◄ — Ω Elder Futhark ►◄ — Ω Younger Futhark ►◄ — Ω Medieval Runes ► — Ω Dalecarlian Runes ►
Ω Ogham ▲► — Ω Duployan Shorthand ►
ぇ *Pitman Shorthand* ►
from Old Turkic (Mongolia) — Ω Old Hungarian ◄
Ω **Latin** ► ABCdefg — Carolingian miniscule (lowercase letter forms)

Americas

文か *Maya* ◄►▼
from Devanagari (India) — Ω Deseret ► — from Hebrew (Israel) — from Lao — Ω Osage ► — Ω Puachue Hmong ► — Nyiakeng
ぇ Canadian Aboriginal ►
か Cherokee ►